

COUNT TO 15, THEN ANSWER ANY ESTIMATION QUESTION

# How Many People Are Inside Disney World Right Now?

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## 1 Buy time, then count to 15

Tell the interviewer you're taking a moment, then breathe and count to 15 in your head. Do it even if you already know how you'd start. Use the count to decide what you'd ask first.

### EXAMPLE

"Give me a few seconds to think this through."

When you hit 15, don't start solving. Ask your question.

## 2 Ask clarifying questions

For an estimation, ask one or two. For a design question, three to five. Pick the ones that change your answer the most. "Inside Disney World" could mean one park, all four theme parks, or the whole property with the hotels and Disney Springs.

### EXAMPLE

"Do you mean one park, all four theme parks, or everywhere on Disney property? And what time of day?"

Repeat their answer back before you move on: "Got it, all four theme parks at 2pm on a normal day."

## 3 Break it apart on paper

Write the question at the top of the page and split it into layers before you do any math. Start with the biggest number you know and work down to the one they asked for. Here, that's the population of the US.

### EXAMPLE

```
People inside the 4 parks at 2pm
└ Americans who go this year: _____
  └ Plus visitors from other countries: _____
    └ Park days per trip: ___
      └ Park visits on a normal day: _____
        └ Share of today's guests inside at 2pm: ___%
```

Leave the blanks empty for now. Turn the page toward the interviewer so they can follow along.

#### 4 Work it top down

Fill in the tree one layer at a time, out loud, and give a reason for every percentage. Round to numbers you can multiply in your head.

##### EXAMPLE

1. About 330 million people live in the US. Disney is a trip most families take once in a long while, so say 1 in 30 goes this year.  
 $330M \div 30 = 11M$  Americans this year
2. Add visitors from other countries. Orlando is a big international trip, so say 4 million.  
 $11M + 4M = 15M$  visitors this year
3. A typical trip is about 5 days, with 3 of them in the parks.  
 $15M \times 3 = 45M$  park visits a year
4. Spread that across the year. Summer and holidays run higher, so treat this as an average day.  
 $45M \div 365 \approx 125,000$  park visits today
5. Some families leave after lunch and others come for the evening, so say half of today's guests are inside at 2pm.  
 $125,000 \times 50\% \approx 62,500$  people right now

If they push back on a percentage, take their number and keep going.

#### 5 Check your number with the interviewer

You can't look anything up in an interview, so the interviewer is your fact check. Say your number and ask if it's in the right range. They'll tell you it's about right, too high, or too low.

##### EXAMPLE

**You:** "That puts me at about 62,500 people inside the four parks at 2pm. Does that feel like the right range?"

**Interviewer:** "I'd go higher."

**You:** "The number I'm least sure of is the 50%. Most families stay until the fireworks, so by 2pm most have arrived and few have left. At 80%, it's  $125,000 \times 80\%$ , about 100,000 people."

**Interviewer:** "That's closer."

If they say it's right, close with your number. If they say higher or lower, don't start over. Change the one assumption you're least sure of, out loud, and rerun the math from that layer down.

### Practice on this one

Set a 5-minute timer, have a friend play the interviewer, and record it. Run all five steps out loud, count included. Play it back and flag any number you said without a reason.

☐ How many people are on the NYC subway right now?

## Score every answer

Use this checklist after each practice run:

- ☐ Did I say "give me a few seconds" and count to 15?
- ☐ Did I ask one or two clarifying questions and repeat the scope back?
- ☐ Did I sketch the layers on paper before any math?
- ☐ Did I give a reason for every percentage?
- ☐ Did I say each line of math out loud?
- ☐ Did I ask if my number was in range and change one assumption at a time?